Pre-Class Assignment: Bengio Essay

"Advanced AI as a Global Public Good and a Global Risk"

ECON 470 — Microeconomics of Artificial Intelligence

Spring 2026

Reading: Yoshua Bengio, "Advanced AI as a Global Public Good and a Global Risk," *The Digitalist Papers*, Vol. 2 (2024). Available at digitalistpapers.com/vol2/bengio.

Due: In person, Monday May 18, at the start of class.

Instructions: Answer each question in 1–3 sentences. These are reading-check questions — they should be quick if you read the essay. You must submit this assignment in person. The assignment must be handwritten. No photocopies will be accepted.

Why we do this: A team of your classmates is presenting this essay and leading a 10-minute discussion afterward. These questions ensure you arrive ready to participate.

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1. Bengio identifies three categories of catastrophic risk from advanced AI. Name all three in one sentence each.
2. The essay argues that competitive market dynamics make AI safety harder to achieve. Why?
3. Bengio distinguishes between "agentic" and "non-agentic" AI systems. Why does he argue that non-agentic systems are safer, and what tradeoff does this involve?
4. The essay invokes the precautionary principle. What does Bengio mean by this, and what analogy does he draw to another field?
5. Pick one of Bengio's claims or proposals that you found either compelling or unconvincing. State it in one sentence, then say why you reacted the way you did.